DELEGATE INSIGHTS

THE FUTURE OF WORK 2026

1.2 Billion Young People Entering the Workforce.

Only 400 Million Formal Jobs Expected.

What Happens Next?

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Summit Focus: #FutureWorks: Designing Jobs for the Digital Age

Perspective Base: Virtual Engagement & Analytics

Platform Context: World Bank Group Youth Summit 2026

1. My Take on the Big Picture

Participating as an online delegate in the World Bank Group Youth Summit 2026 has completely changed how I think about global employment. Tuning into the high-level streams alongside thousands of remote delegates worldwide, the core issue hit me instantly. Over the next ten to fifteen years, a massive wave of **1.2 billion young people** will step into the global job market. But under our current corporate systems, developing countries are only on track to create about **400 million formal jobs**. As someone tracking these metrics closely from an analytical standpoint, this leaves a staggering gap of **800 million next-generation workers** facing an economy that simply isn't built for them.

> THE EMPLOYMENT DISCONNECT IN SIMPLE NUMBERS
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> **1.2 Billion New Workers vs. 400 Million Available Jobs → An 800 Million Seat Shortfall**

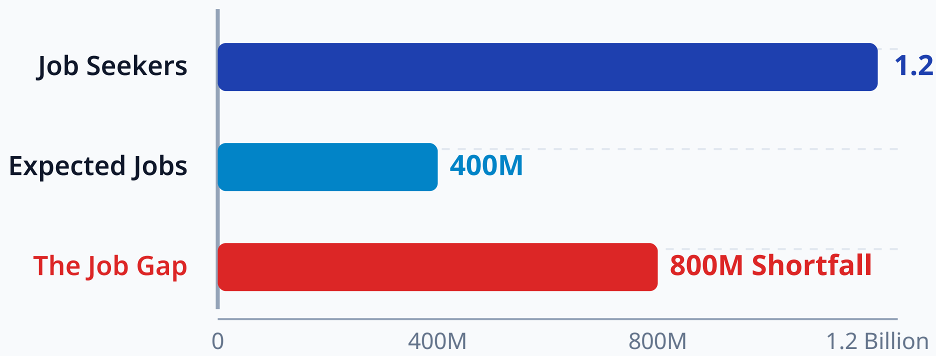

Figure 1.1: The global employment imbalance that we need to fix.

The main theme of this entire journey, *#FutureWorks: Designing Jobs for the Digital Age*, tackles this imbalance directly across three core sectors: education, enterprise, and agriculture. As an online delegate, my focus was on tracing how these sectors are affected by digital automation, how new development financing models can act as a shield, and what things actually look like in areas torn apart by conflict or economic instability. In this brief, I want to capture exactly how we move from the hard problems we mapped out on Day 1 to the practical, community-driven answers we reviewed on Day 2.

2. Realities and Hard Choices from Day 1

How Automation is Changing the Career Starting Line

One of the most intense debates during our initial sessions centered on how automation is eroding traditional entry-level jobs. For decades, emerging economies relied on simple digital tasks like entry-level data input, basic call centers, invoice sorting, and simple code testing as stepping stones to move high volumes of young people into the formal corporate world. These basic roles gave us our first taste of professional life, provided steady income, and helped us fund our next career moves.

But as I listened to the opening panels, it became obvious that AI agents and language models are taking over these precise tasks at a lower cost and with zero downtime. This instantly pushes the technical starting line higher for young professionals, rendering basic software training paths obsolete.

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[OLD PATHWAY]
Basic Computer Use → Entry-Level Digital Tasks → On-The-Job Learning → Career Growth

[THE MODERNDAY SHIFT]
Basic Computer Use → [AI Agents Automate Entry Floor] → Missing Career Stepping Stone

[OUR NEW PATHWAY FORWARD]
Advanced Tech Literacy → AI Orchestration & Human Supervision → Resilient High-Value Placement
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To win a formal job today, simply knowing how to navigate basic software isn't enough. We have to know how to supervise, customize, and prompt these automated tools. For millions of young people living in regions without access to advanced technology training centers, this changing baseline risks creating immediate economic exclusion. If the baseline stepping stones vanish, it becomes much harder to build basic soft habits like team accountability and proactive project management, making alternative regional hubs essential.

The Learning Gap: School Timelines vs. Market Speed

A massive point of frustration shared by my fellow remote youth delegates is the widening gap between what we learn in school and what the modern tech world actually demands. The issue is structural: it takes a traditional university or state vocational board around **three to five years** to redesign a curriculum, secure regulatory approvals, and update training courses. This long pipeline is fundamentally out of sync with a market that updates its standard tools every **12 to 18 months**.

This means millions of us graduate with degrees that are already out-of-date. Furthermore, traditional schools still over-index on passive text memorization and single-subject tests. Meanwhile, modern employers are looking for practical capabilities combined with deep human traits like flexible problem-solving, cross-cultural collaboration, and the ability to operate across remote, asynchronous workflows.

The True Cost of Early-Career Exclusion

When an economy allows millions of its youngest citizens to sit idle at the start of their career lifecycles, the fallout is permanent. For an individual, extended early career gaps halt the accumulation of foundational work habits and depress potential lifetime earnings for decades. At a macro level, it threatens social stability. In fragile or post-conflict zones, leaving a highly connected, energetic youth population with zero economic traction creates a volatile environment. This dynamic can derail community peace-building efforts and drive irregular migration patterns that drain developing economies of their brightest minds.

This cycle traps entire families in vulnerable financial loops, placing a heavier fiscal burden on state welfare networks. To break it, we must shift from rigid, long-term degree programs toward modular, skills-first frameworks that can update at the same speed as the digital market.

A New View of the Digital Divide

The discussions at the summit clearly redefined what the "digital divide" means today. It is no longer just about whether a village has basic cellular coverage. Instead, it is about the quality, cost, and equity of that access across three distinct levels:

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LEVEL 1: THE HARD GRID → Fast fiber networks, resilient 5G cells, and steady electricity.
LEVEL 2: THE COST INDEX → Is high-speed internet affordable compared to local daily wages?
LEVEL 3: REAL LITERACY → Do citizens have the training to build and create value using the tool?
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Large youth populations across sub-Saharan Africa, rural Latin America, and South Asia remain stuck with slow, expensive mobile data. Frequent power grid failures mean that young tech talent cannot participate reliably in global remote work, which demands continuous availability. I also noticed that young women face the highest hurdles, often restricted by localized cultural biases from using community digital spaces or owning their own hardware, shutting them out of borderless learning networks.

3. Direct Perspectives Across Regions

Our regional breakout sessions brought home an essential lesson: while code travels across borders instantly, our solutions have to respect the realities on the ground. The summit highlighted three unique settings, proving that uniform, top-down approaches do not work:

- **Sub-Saharan Africa:** Since more than 80% of our peers operate within the informal economy, standard online corporate job boards do not fit. Our focus here must be on using mobile money systems and light digital platforms to help small street businesses and farming cooperatives track their data, building alternative credit records to bypass traditional banks.
- **South & East Asia:** The traditional path of moving rural workers into big urban manufacturing plants is shrinking as automated robots change assembly lines. The strategy is shifting toward localized digital hubs that rapidly retrain workers for new services, like remote data maintenance and automated system supervision.
- **MENA & Conflict Zones:** In areas where local banking systems are broken or state institutions are unstable, borderless digital work is a literal lifeline. Young professionals are using decentralized freelance platforms and stablecoins to land remote jobs and receive international payments securely without relying on legacy local banks.

4. Innovative Financing Channels

From a financial standpoint, solving an 800-million-job shortfall cannot be handled by charity or short-term state grants alone. The panels focused on smart financial models that use public development funds to derisk investments, encouraging large pools of private corporate capital to step in and turn small projects into scalable market solutions.

Using Blended Capital to Build Last-Mile Networks

Development banks must stop trying to build massive public telecom projects entirely on their own. Instead, they should deploy their capital to structure derisking mechanisms that draw private commercial funds into underserved areas. A key tool we analyzed was using **First-Loss Guarantees** on digital infrastructure bonds. Under this approach, a development bank agrees to absorb the first wave of defaults or project delays if a rural internet expansion plan runs into regional issues. By taking on that initial layer of risk, the investment grade of the overall bond is protected, making it safe for large entities like pension funds to invest commercial scale capital, wiring rural communities directly into the global cloud.

Risk-Sharing Frameworks for Education

The core plenaries made it clear that traditional student loans are deeply flawed for emerging economies. They burden young people with rigid debts before they even secure a job, killing any early entrepreneurial spirit. The summit highlighted two better alternatives:

- **Income Share Agreements (ISAs):** Here, an impact fund covers our technical tuition upfront. We commit to paying back a fixed, predictable percentage of our salary, but *only* after we land a professional role that pays above a verified living baseline, aligning the school's financial success directly with our employment.
- **Sovereign Skills Bonds:** Governments can issue social impact bonds where private investors fund national digital bootcamps upfront. The state pays a return to these investors based entirely on independent verifications of long-term reductions in local youth unemployment, shifting the training risk away from taxpayers.

Data-Driven, Collateral-Free Business Credit Lines

Young business owners in emerging markets are routinely turned away by banks because they do not own physical land or major corporate property to use as collateral. The financial panels proved that we can bypass this hurdle by using **Digital Data Trust Layers**. By pulling data from everyday alternative streams like mobile money logs, e-commerce cash flows, and digital supplier logs, fintech platforms can build highly accurate credit scores, unlocking credit lines without requiring land deeds.

5. Agriculture Reimagined as a Tech Career

A transformative insight from Day 1 was the realization that technology is altering farming, transforming it from a manual survival activity into a sophisticated, data-driven career. This is critical because agriculture remains the single largest employer of youth across emerging markets, making it a key space for generating high-value digital roles that keep young talent thriving in their local communities.

Data-Driven Farming and Precision Systems

By bringing accessible internet-of-things (IoT) soil sensors, mapping drones, and real-time satellite imaging to the field, traditional farms are turning into smart spaces. Young professionals are stepping into technical roles that skip manual field labor entirely. We are seeing our peers build careers as drone flight operators, soil data analysts, and smart micro-irrigation specialists. These tech tools help rural areas boost food output, track supply transparency, and shield local ecosystems from climate disruptions.

Open Digital Marketplaces

Historically, small family farms lose a huge chunk of their profits to local middle traders who control transport and access to buyers. The use of decentralized mobile commerce networks lets young agriculture business owners create direct sales channels. These open platforms connect local farms directly with large commercial buyers and urban food networks, ensuring the primary producers keep a fair share of the value. This changes farming into an organized, profitable profession for our generation.

Furthermore, stabilizing these income cycles fuels secondary local businesses. When a young farmer turns a predictable profit, they spend on local services and update their tools. This creates non-farm technical roles like equipment maintenance, solar installation, and local digital marketplace management, building a resilient rural economic cluster. This closed loop provides a solid cushion against volatile global market shifts, proving that agricultural software design is a prime entry track for young tech builders.

6. Day 2 Insights from Global Leaders

On Day 2, the focus shifted from high-level frameworks to personal, human leadership. I followed the **Leadership Series** stream closely, featuring **Paschal Donohoe**, the World Bank Group's Managing Director & Chief Knowledge Officer, in a live conversation moderated by youth representative **Shay**. Having previously served as Ireland's Minister for Finance and President of the Euro Group, Donohoe shared a unique view on how a modern "Knowledge Bank" can turn evidence into actual jobs for us.

When **Shay** asked about the meaning of a "Knowledge Bank," **Paschal Donohoe** explained that under President **Ajay Banga**, the World Bank Group was restructured to organize its massive institutional knowledge into five clean pillars: People (health and social policy), Planet (economic policy), Infrastructure, Digital Knowledge, and Food/Climate/Energy. Donohoe noted that his role is to ensure that successful job-creation models built in one part of the world are quickly and efficiently shared across other regions so local teams do not have to start from scratch. Hearing him address the thousands of us watching online made me appreciate the true scale of virtual synchronization.

> ***Paschal Donohoe:*** *"The way in which we need to package youth employment data is by making the knowledge as practical as possible... pitch our advice below the macro and above the micro when it comes to thinking about labor markets." [00:17:06]*

When discussing resilient sectors for youth, **Paschal Donohoe** highlighted high-value manufacturing, health care, and food/agriculture as spaces that will remain highly resilient against automation and AI disruptions. Reflecting on his recent field travels to Mozambique and South Africa, he emphasized that the imagination and resilience of young people worldwide are at an all-time high.

The session became incredibly relatable when **Paschal Donohoe** shared his own career path. He revealed that his very first job out of school was working in sales for Proctor & Gamble, selling truckloads of Pampers nappies in London and Birmingham. He later resigned from P&G to run for political office—and actually lost his very first election, leaving him with no job at all. This moment of failure taught him more about resilience than any early victory would have.

During the open Q&A, several student and delegate questions stood out to me:

- **Joey Drosski**, a student from Trinity College Dublin, asked about career planning. Donohoe responded honestly that he never rigidly planned his path to the World Bank, advising us to focus completely on the value of where we are right now rather than obsessing over corporate titles or competition.

- **Dafo**, a delegate from Canada, asked how the Bank can better package youth data for state financing. Donohoe reiterated the importance of providing practical, sector-specific operational blueprints that sit comfortably between broad macro theories and micro tasks.
- Answering a question from **Himakshi** (a student from UPenn) regarding knowledge sharing, Donohoe highlighted that the ultimate secret sauce for any government looking to build long-term opportunity is simple: **Education, education, education.** Supporting teachers and maximizing access is an investment that always yields a return.

7. Field Delivery and Real-World Examples

Right after the leadership panels, Day 2 moved directly into the final rounds of the Global Youth Pitch Competition. Watching our peers pitch their ideas via the live chat feed showed me exactly how young innovators are solving the "last-mile delivery failures" that often stall big development programs. They are not waiting for regional tech infrastructure to become flawless; they are building smart tools that run beautifully within existing local limitations.

I selected three distinct startup models from the finals that serve as brilliant examples of turning waste and environmental hurdles into engines for youth employment:

CASE 1: EAGRO (Africa Track)

The Local Problem: Small farms produce the bulk of regional food, but farmers operate blindly without agronomic data. Traditional agronomists are overwhelmed, serving up to 5,000 farmers each. Most digital tools require smartphones and continuous internet, leaving 55 million last-mile farmers disconnected.

The Technical Solution: EAGRO built an offline-first AI system. They compressed complex crop data models by

70%

, allowing them to run locally on low-cost edge devices. The system texts hyper-local crop tips directly to basic feature phones via standard SMS, skipping the internet grid entirely.

The Business Model: They use a lean B2B model where agricultural institutions and credit providers pay for the service to insulate their loan portfolios against crop failure. They have boosted crop yields by 10% and raised net farm incomes by $113 per hectare.

CASE 2: PANPA (Asia Track)

The Local Problem: Traditional flooded rice farming is a major driver of climate change, generating over 50% of agricultural methane emissions across Asia. A method called Alternate Wetting and Drying (AWD) cuts these emissions in half, but adoption is flat because it requires heavy physical monitoring and offers no immediate cash reward.

The Technical Solution: PANPA Technologies processes public Google satellite data through a machine learning layer to track moisture profiles. The platform maps optimal watering schedules and sends commands directly to local water pumps, automating the AWD cycle hands-free.

The Business Model: They digitized carbon credit tracking, replacing manual field auditors with satellite verification to cut compliance costs by

90%

. They monetize by taking a 6% fee on the carbon credit payouts channeled directly back to the farmers.

CASE 3: SANKA FRESH (W. Africa)

The Local Problem: In agricultural hubs like Ghana, between 30% and 50% of fresh crops spoil before reaching urban markets due to broken cold storage, unstable energy grids, and isolated local traders who lack transparent pricing.

The Technical Solution: Sanka Fresh sets up modular, solar-powered community cold storage hubs right next to farming clusters. These hubs link to an offline digital market running on SMS and an automated sensor array. The sensors track internal temperatures and trigger mobile text alerts to local operators before any food spoils.

The Business Model: To match local realities, they use a "pay-per-use" micro-rental fee. Farmers only pay for the specific storage crates they use, removing upfront costs. The platform links farms with urban corporate buyers while hiring local youth to run the solar hubs.

8. Practical Steps for Everyone Involved

To turn these collective summit insights into real results, we need to map out simple, clear steps for each major group in our global community:

For Us as Students and Innovators

- **Build a Double-Sided Skillset:** Avoid focusing on just general business or basic software design. Pair a hard tech skill (like Python data analysis or edge system setup) with a deep understanding of a traditional field like logistics, farming, or local micro-finance.
- **Build Public Portfolios over Resumes:** Stop relying on simple paper resumes. Build public portfolios that show you can execute. Share your open-source code tweaks, upload working hardware sketches, or post simple write-ups of actual community tests where you helped solve a problem.

For Universities and Schools

- **Shift to Quick, Modular Skills Badges:** Move away from slow, rigid degree paths that take years to change. Partner with actual companies to offer rapid technical courses that can update instantly as fresh workplace tools hit the market.
- **Create Combined Project Labs:** Break down the walls between different academic departments. Set up mandatory innovation labs that bring software students, finance majors, and agricultural teams together to build multi-layered answers for local issues.

For Corporate Employers and Firms

- **Hire for Skills, Not Degrees:** Completely remove generic university degree filters from your application portals. Use practical, portfolio-based skill tests to evaluate an applicant's ability to complete actual tasks, removing institutional bias.
- **Build Workflows for Remote Inclusion:** Design your internal company communications to support asynchronous, remote collaboration. This makes it easy to hire talented young professionals from rural areas or conflict zones, bringing real income back to their communities.

For Government Policymakers

- **Treat High-Speed Data as a Utility:** Prioritize building broadband grids and stable electricity with the same urgency as roads and clean water. Focus infrastructure spending on connecting remote towns and community centers to build our digital floor.

- **Open Legal Sandboxes for Financial Tech:** Create flexible legal spaces that let local fintech platforms test alternative credit scoring tools and mobile payment systems without being crushed by massive legal compliance costs early on.

9. My Personal Reflection

Synthesizing everything I saw over these intense days as an online participant at the World Bank Youth Summit has brought me to a deep realization. The twin pressures of an 800-million formal job deficit and shifting climate patterns cannot be solved with old industrial rules. The historic path of moving workers from rural fields into centralized urban factories is breaking down under the weight of automation.

But what inspired me most from my virtual vantage point was seeing that our generation isn't looking at these disruptions as a crisis, but as a blank canvas for building something better. By using lightweight, community-driven tools like offline AI systems, satellite-tracked carbon financing, and solar-powered cold storage, young leaders are building a more inclusive economy from the ground up. This completely redefines my view of resilience. The future of work won't depend on how passively we accept automation. It will be defined by how courageously we leverage borderless digital tools to create opportunities, fairness, and real growth where traditional systems have left a void.

> **Official Summit Broadcast Records & Video Availability:** This independent brief captures my personal journey, structural analysis, and synthesis of the proceedings conducted as an online delegate during the 13th Annual World Bank Group Youth Summit. The full video recordings for both days are completely available for public recheck and verification via the official broadcast records: Day 1 High-Level Plenaries and Panels (https://youtu.be/CHY6s3WFcSE) and Day 2 Managing Director Leadership Series & Pitch Finals (https://www.youtube.com/live/JUo4PwGrI2k).